Resistance to Backsliding: The Role of Democratic Conceptions

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Abstract

We examine who mobilizes against democratic backsliding, focusing on mass protests against the judicial overhaul advanced by the Israeli government in 2023. As contemporary subversion of democracy is often driven by governments that won an electoral majority, we posit that protesting against the government's actions requires people to have a thick conception of democracy that goes beyond majority rule. Drawing on panel data collected before and after the overhaul's announcement, we show that citizens vary substantially in their conception of democracy, and that a thick conception not only predicts protesting against backsliding but also moderates the role of other key factors in mobilizing against democratic erosion. The findings highlight the role of small-d democrats in safeguarding democracy.

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1 Introduction

In January 2023, the recently elected Israeli government presented a comprehensive plan to concentrate power in the hands of the executive and weaken the system of checks and balances (Roznai and Cohen, 2023). The judicial overhaul included steps to severely hamper the judiciary's ability to constrain the power of the executive branch and was thus interpreted by many as a direct assault on the country's democratic system. This drive toward democratic backsliding—that is, the "erosion of democratic institutions, rules and norms that results from the actions of duly elected governments" (Haggard and Kaufman, 2021, 1)—was soon met with the largest protests in the country's history, as hundreds of thousands of Israelis took to the streets. As reported in *Foreign Policy*, about "20 percent of all Israelis have protested at one time or another against the judicial coup"—making it one of the largest protests in recent Western history.[1] These protests were seen by commentators as responsible for the government's decision to halt the legislative drive and reverse course on major elements of the judicial overhaul (Gidron, 2023; Shultziner, 2023). Steven Levitsky, a leading scholar of democracy, commented on these protests: "When folks from Turkey, Hungary, Venezuela, or Nicaragua ask me what to do [against backsliding], I tell them — *mobilize the people as they did in Israel*."[2]

But who were the people mobilized in Israel? This question gains importance as concerns over democratic backsliding proliferate (Diamond, 2024; Holliday et al., 2024; Kaltwasser and Taggart, 2025; Levitsky and Way, 2023; Riedl, Friesen, McCoy and Roberts, 2024; Scheppele, 2018). Yet while there is a burgeoning literature about support for democratic transgressions (Druckman et al., 2024; Jacob, 2024; Krishnarajan, 2023; Svolik et al., 2023; Wunsch, Jacob and Derksen, 2025), research on opposition to the erosion of democracy is still in early stages (Cleary and Öztürk, 2022; Gamboa, 2022)—despite mass protests against backsliding in countries as diverse as South Korea, Mexico, Serbia and Israel.

To address this gap, we lay out a set of potential explanations for people's mobilization

[1] Aaron David Miller, "What Israel Can Teach the U.S. About Confronting a Constitutional Crisis," Foreign Policy, May 18, 2023. https://foreignpolicy.com/2023/05/18/israel-judicial-reform-protests-us-constitutional-crisis-democracy-lessons/

[2] Roni Dori, "The Greatest Threat to Democracy Comes not from Extremists but from Moderates who will Do Everything to Win." Calcalist, January 18, 2024 (Hebrew). https://newmedia.calcalist.co.il/magazine-18-01-24/m01.html

against backsliding. We use panel data collected before and after the announcement of the judicial overhaul in Israel to assess their predictive value, distinguishing between *active mobilization* against backsliding and *attitudinal* opposition. Beyond common explanations centered on the role of ideology, dislike of political opponents and affect toward strongmen leaders heading the backsliding charge, our focus here is on the role of people's conceptions of democracy (Chu, Williamson and Yeung, 2024; Ferrer et al., 2025). Given that contemporary democratic erosion is predominantly driven by elected governments, we conjecture that for people to actively contest backsliding they need to have a thick understanding of democracy that goes beyond majoritarianism. In other words, they must see democracy as more than mere majority rule—recognizing it as a system grounded in constraints on power and the protection of fundamental rights.

Our findings support these conjectures and highlight how conceptions of democracy interact with ideological, affective and personalistic features of the political system in shaping opposition to backsliding. We find that participation in protest against backsliding is strongly associated with a thick conception of democracy. Furthermore, a thick democratic conception increases the likelihood that individuals already opposed to backsliding will choose to actively participate in efforts to block it. Finally, a thick conception of democracy amplifies the effects that affective and ideological indicators appear to have on mobilization. Notably, ease of protest (e.g., living in proximity to the sites of the major protests) played no significant role in shaping participation in the Israeli protest movement.

These results speak to the role of thick understandings of democracy as a guardrail against democratic backsliding, while also suggesting that this factor alone may not be enough. And while affective polarization and strongmen leadership have been highlighted as potential drivers of democratic backsliding, our analyses show that these factors may also have the opposite effect: when strong leaders and their parties generate intense negative emotions among those who oppose them, they also help galvanize protest against backsliding efforts. Our findings also highlight the promise, and challenge, in constructing a broad front of protesters who share a non-majoritarian view of democracy but are also divided ideologically on other issues. Finally, the results highlight the importance of better understanding the origins and over-time stability of people's conceptions of democracy in this tumultuous period

when democratic institutions are intensely challenged from within.

2 Theoretical expectations

The literature on political participation has explored multiple factors—affective, ideological and sociodemographic—that help explain why some people are more likely to protest than others (Oser, 2022; McAdam, 1986; Schussman and Soule, 2005). So far, this theoretical framework has not been applied to the study of mass protests against democratic backsliding. While our primary focus is on people's conception of democracy as an explanation for resistance, we highlight several additional factors that could be especially relevant to participation in this type of protest.

2.1 Conceptions of democracy

While public opinion surveys report broad support for democracy across the globe (Adserà, Arenas and Boix, 2023; Ejaz and Thornton, 2024; Wike et al., 2017), this supposed consensus overlooks deep disagreement among citizens regarding the essence of democracy (Krishnarajan, 2023; Lu and Chu, 2021). Recent scholarship has identified divergent conceptions of democracy, each highlighting different institutional settings and normative priorities. For instance, Wunsch, Jacob and Derksen (2025) distinguish three mass-level conceptions of democracy: liberal, which emphasizes the protection of civil rights; majoritarian, which prioritizes the majority's ability to overrule the minority; and authoritarian, which frames restrictions on civic freedoms as necessary to preserve public order.Chu, Williamson and Yeung (2024) distinguish between a wider set of understandings of democracy: electoral, liberal, institutional, populist, loyalist, substantive, technocratic and direct. While different scholars rely on varying typologies of democratic conceptions (König, Siewert and Ackermann, 2022), the key point is that there is substantial variation in the way people conceive of what democracy entails.

What are the implications of variations in public perceptions of democracy for mass reactions to backsliding? This issue has been examined in the context of *support* for lifting constraints over the executive. In Poland, for instance, a more majoritarian conception

of democracy was associated with greater support for subjecting the judiciary to the government (Wunsch, Jacob and Derksen, 2025). Building on this work, we also expect that understandings of democracy may explain *opposition* to democratic backsliding.

Since democratic backsliding is about the concentration of power in the hands of the executive through the use of majoritarian justifications (Haggard and Kaufman, 2021, 72-73), a thicker conception of democracy—which recognizes the importance of majority rule but also of civil liberties—may be associated with opposition to and mobilization against backsliding. Those who have a thicker conception of democracy, by virtue of espousing this view, should be more likely to see backsliding initiatives undertaken by a democratically elected government as transgressing its mandate. Such individuals should be more likely to see the principles violated by top-down backsliding drives as central to their conception of democracy and would be more likely to interpret such initiatives as posing a more grievous and direct threat, thus reducing barriers for protesting against such harm. Indeed, a cross-national experiment shows that civic education which includes information about the importance of independent courts—a potential proxy for a thicker conception of democracy—decreases supports for politicians who violate democratic norms (Eroglu et al., 2025); yet whether this effect translates also into mobilization against backsliding remains unexplored in this study.

There is reason to expect conceptions of democracy would play a role also in the Israeli context, where the judicial overhaul was explicitly discussed in terms of majoritarian versus liberal understandings of democracy. For example, in a rare public speech, then-Chief Justice Esther Hayut argued: "We have all heard that the main grounds on which the plan [the judicial overhaul] is justified is the will of the majority and the decision of the majority. Indeed, majority rule is a fundamental principle that lies at the core of a democratic regime, but democracy is not just the rule of the majority."[3] And indeed, more majoritarian conceptions of democracy were predictive of greater support for the overhaul (Gidron et al., 2025). We thus expect that the opposite is also true: those who reject a strict majoritarian conception of democracy and adopt a thicker conceptualization should be more likely to protest against the judicial overhaul.

[3]Nitsan Shafir, "Supreme Court President Hayut blasts judicial reform plan." Globes, January 12, 2023.

2.2 Ideology

In addition to conceptions of democracy, ideological leanings are also likely to play a role in shaping protest behavior. Comparative research in Europe shows that voters of parties that lost in the last elections and those who are ideologically opposed to the government are especially likely to participate in protests (Borbáth and Gessler, 2020, 911). The judicial overhaul was led by Benjamin Netanyahu's right-wing government—perhaps the most ideologically radical in the country's history (Rahat, Gidron and Shamir, 2025)—making left-wing supporters the immediate suspects to participate in the protests against it. Furthermore, left-wing actors have historically prioritized mass protests compared to their right-wing counterparts (Hutter and Kriesi, 2013, 382). We therefore expect left-wing ideological self-identification to predict participation in the protest. We note that this expectation says little about participation in the protests among centrist voters, a segment of the electorate that has dramatically grown in size since the mid-2000s (Yakter and Tessler, 2023).

2.3 Affect toward out-parties

Affect toward political opponents may also shape the propensity to protest against democratic backsliding. Affective polarization, or dislike and animosity toward political opponents, has been intensely discussed in the context of concerns over democratic backsliding. On the one hand, experimental evidence challenges the assumed direct relationship between negative affective evaluations of partisan opponents and anti-democratic attitudes (Broockman, Kalla and Westwood, 2023). On the other hand, there is evidence that individuals who are more affectively polarized are more likely to support democratic transgressions when those are taken by their preferred politicians (Druckman et al., 2024; Krishnarajan, 2023). In the Israeli context, dislike of opposition parties was a key factor in shaping support for the judicial overhaul among supporters of the ruling coalition (Gidron et al., 2025).

We conjecture that levels of affective polarization should also be associated with protest against backsliding. First, previous work shows that affective polarization predicts protest participation (Bettarelli, Close and Van Haute, 2022; Warner, 2025). Second, and more specifically, individuals who are more openly hostile towards a ruling government that ini-

tiates backsliding should be more likely to oppose measures intended to concentrate power in the hands of the (disliked) government. Third, individuals who are strongly affectively polarized against the ruling parties may derive satisfaction from seeing these parties fail in their political efforts.

2.4 Affect toward the backsliding leader

In an era of personalized politics (Rahat and Kenig, 2018), we should consider affect not only toward parties but also toward leaders (Reiljan et al., 2024). Backsliding is often promoted by strongmen leaders, who enjoy a strong emotional bond with their supporters (Frantz, Kendall-Taylor and Wright, 2024). And indeed, previous research in the Israeli context finds that support for democratic backsliding is stronger among those who express a strong emotional bond with the leader heading the backsliding effort (Gidron et al., 2025).

Yet personalistic politics may be a double-edged sword: just as strongmen leaders benefit from an intense emotional attachment with their supporters, they can be disliked but their opponents (Luo and Przeworski, 2023). This strong animosity may help galvanize opposition against moves that erode democracy, as those who intensely dislike the leader heading the backsliding effort may be more likely to protest against it. In the Israeli case, Prime Minister Netanyahu's affective evaluations by his opponents have become increasingly negative over the last decade among left-wing and centrist voters (Amitai, Gidron and Yair, 2025).

2.5 Cost of participation

Lastly, practical considerations may condition citizens' ability to protest (Schussman and Soule, 2005). Scholars of social movements have long emphasized the importance of "personal constraints that may increase the costs and risks of movement participation, such as full-time employment, marriage and family responsibilities" (McAdam, 1986, 70). To this list of constraints we add the distance of one's residence from the protests, assuming it increases the costs of participation. Our final expectation is thus that married people, parents of young children and those who live farther from the central cities where the main demonstrations took place, are less likely to participate.

3 The Israeli judicial overhaul

We test these theoretical expectations regarding protests against backsliding in the context of the demonstrations that took place in Israel during early 2023 in opposition to the government's plan for a judicial overhaul. The plan consisted of multiple legal and quasi-constitutional measures, with the overall goal of reducing the checks on the executive branch of government by significantly weakening the judiciary (Roznai and Cohen, 2023). For example, one of the major changes proposed was to alter the selection of the committee that appoints judges in a way that would provide the ruling coalition a guaranteed majority. In the words of then-Chief Justice Hayut, the proposed overhaul represented nothing short of a "fatal blow" to Israeli democracy.[4] The Israeli case, despite its particularities, should be considered within the broader context of global threats to democracy: the overhaul was devised with advice from officials from the PiS-led Polish government, among the paradigmatic cases of democratic backsliding in the comparative literature (Haggard and Kaufman, 2021).[5]

The protest that emerged to oppose the overhaul was of unprecedented scale in Israeli history and stood out in comparison to protests across the advanced democracies. First, it encompassed a large swath of the population: according to one estimate, 20% of Israelis participated in the at some point in protests against the judicial overhaul.[6] To put it in context, an analysis of European survey data collected from 2002 to 2016 found that on average, less than 7% of respondents reported participating in demonstrations (Borbáth and Gessler, 2020). Second, the protest persisted for a long period of time: its main thrust took place between the announcement of the overhaul in January 2023 and the outbreak of the war in Gaza and Lebanon in October 2023. Third, civil society organizations spanning the ideological spectrum joined in the protests, from business organizations to labor unions. The protest managed to slow down and for a while, even successfully block the overhaul.

[4] Jeremy Sharon, "In fiery speech, Hayut says judicial shakeup plan 'fatal blow to Israeli democracy'," Times of Israel, January 12, 2023. https://www.timesofisrael.com/in-fiery-speech-hayut-says-judicial-shakeup-plan-fatal-blow-to-israeli-democracy/

[5] Shaun Walker, "Hungary and Poland provide model for Israel's assault on judiciary," The Guardian, April 15, 2023. https://www.theguardian.com/world/2023/apr/16/hungary-poland-provide-model-israel-assault-judiciary-netanyahu

[6] Aaron David Miller, "What Israel Can Teach the U.S. About Confronting a Constitutional Crisis," Foreign Policy, May 18, 2023. https://foreignpolicy.com/2023/05/18/israel-judicial-reform-protests-us-constitutional-crisis-democracy-lessons/

However, efforts to renew it re-emerged in 2024, during Israel's war in Gaza.

4 Data and research design

To test our predictions regarding participation in the protests, we use panel survey data from the Israel Polarization Panel (Gidron, Sheffer and Mor, 2022). We utilize two consecutive surveys: one collected between January 2 and 9 and the other between April 2 and 11, at the peak of the protests. We measure our predictors—conceptions of democracy, ideological placement, affective evaluations of Netanyahu and opposing parties, and personal characteristics related to the cost of participation—based on data collected *prior* to the announcement of the overhaul on January 4. Participation in the protest is measured in April, at the height of mobilization against the overhaul, while the largest protests were already taking place. This research design allays concerns of reverse causality, for example the possibility that respondents aligned their conception of democracy because of their views of the overhaul. At the same time, this dataset also has one major limitation: it contains only Jewish respondents, due to challenges in repeating sampling of a representative sample of Arab citizens of Israel (Gidron, Sheffer and Mor, 2022, 3).

Our dependent variable is a binary indicator of participation in protests based on respondents' answer to the following question: "Did you take part in the protests against the judicial reform?" This variable takes the value of 1 if a person participated in a protest against the overhaul, and 0 otherwise. In additional analyses, we consider attitudinal opposition to the overhaul as the outcome variable rather than the active participation in protests.

Moving to the independent variables, to capture perceptions of democracy, we asked respondents: "With which of the two following views on the nature of democracy do you agree more: the claim that every regime that follows the principle of majority rule is a democracy, or the claim that in order for a regime to be truly democratic other principles must be observed, such as protecting human rights?" Responses ranged from 0 (every regime that follows the principle of majority rule is a democracy) to 10 (for a regime to be truly democratic it must observe principles such as protecting human rights). We measure respondents' ideological position based on the following question: "Where would you position yourself on

a left-right scale, where 0 is the left end and 10 is the right"?" Affective evaluations toward opposing parties and Netanyahu were measured with the feeling thermometer, which ranged from 0 (rejection/hatred) to 10 (support/sympathy). Socio-demographic questions include three variables that proxy for costs of participation in the protests: family status, having young kids, and residing far away from the country's center (where the bulk of the protests take place). The definition and coding of the key variables in the analysis are summarized in Table 1. Descriptive statistics are summarized in Table 2.

5 Results

We begin by examining the distribution across society of our main independent variable: conceptions of democracy. As shown in the bottom panel of Figure 1, the median score is 7, but about a third of respondents placed themselves at 5 or below, i.e., closer to a thin conception (agreeing with the statement: "every regime that follows the principle of majority rule is a democracy"). At the other end of the scale, about 45% placed themselves between 8-10 on the scale, i.e. view protection of basic individual rights, in addition to majority rule, as a fundamental component of democracy.

In the upper panel we examine the degree to which conceptions of democracy are associated with participation in the protests. As the figure shows, rates of participation in the protests were indeed much higher among those with a thicker understanding of democracy. Among respondents who subscribe to a fully majoritarian interpretation of democracy, there were no protesters against the judicial overhaul. Among those who placed themselves in the middle of the scale, levels of participation were already higher than 10%, and among those with the least majoritarian interpretation – the rate of participation exceeds 40%.

Previous work has already demonstrated that a majoritarian interpretation of democracy is associated with support for backsliding (Gidron et al., 2025; Grossman et al., 2022; Wunsch, Jacob and Derksen, 2025). Our findings show that the opposite holds also with respect to active mobilization against it. However, understandings of democracy are likely associated with demographic variables as well as with our other explanatory factors. We therefore turn to examine the results with multivariate regression models.

Table 1: Definition of Variables

Variable	**Explanation**
Protested	Participated in protests against the overhaul. Only respondents who expressed objection or a neutral attitude toward the overhaul were asked whether they participated in a protest against it.
Opposed overhaul	A binary outcome variable that equals 1 for participants who said they are opposed or very much opposed to the reform, and 0 otherwise.
Religiosity	Self-reported religiosity level: Secular, Traditionalist, Religious, Ultra-orthodox
Single	Includes: single, widowed, and divorced-or-separated.
Resides close to protests	Resides in one of the two central districts ("Tel-Aviv" or "Center"), where most large and consistent demonstrations took place.
Out-bloc animosity	Weighted feeling thermometer scores. For each respondent, the scores used are only those referring to parties belonging to the out-bloc. *Standardized for analysis.*
Dislike of Netanyahu	Thermometer score toward PM Netanyahu, running from 0 (hate) to 10 (love). *Transposed and standardized for analysis.*
Ideologically Left-leaning	Self-placement on a 0 to 10 left-right scale, where 0 is the left end and 10 is the right. *Transposed and standardized for analysis.*
Definition of Democracy	Self-placement on a 0 to 10 conception of democracy scale, where 0 = "every regime that follows the principle of majority rule is a democracy" and 10 = "for a regime to be truly democratic it must observe certain principles such as human rights." *Transposed and standardized for analysis.*

Note: The table presents the measurement of the main variables used in the analysis.

Models 1-6 in Table 3 report results of a linear probability model where the dependent variable is an indicator of whether or not the respondent participated in protests against the

Table 2: Descriptive statistics

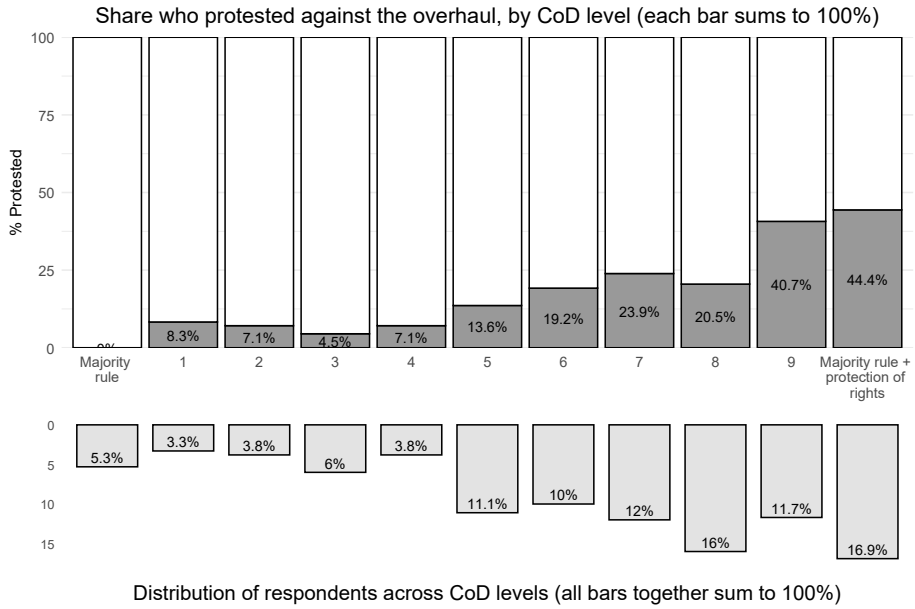
Category	Variable	Type	obs	mean	sd	min	max
Outcome variable	Protested against	binary	732	0.23	0.42	0.00	1.00
	Opposed to reform	binary	732	0.54	0.50	0.00	1.00
Socio-Demographics	Female	binary	732	0.45	0.50	0.00	1.00
	18-34 years old	binary	732	0.13	0.34	0.00	1.00
	35-54	binary	732	0.57	0.50	0.00	1.00
	55+	binary	732	0.30	0.46	0.00	1.00
	College degree	binary	732	0.64	0.48	0.00	1.00
Religiosity	Secular	binary	732	0.64	0.48	0.00	1.00
	Traditionalist	binary	732	0.17	0.38	0.00	1.00
	Religious	binary	732	0.13	0.33	0.00	1.00
	Ultra-orthodox	binary	732	0.07	0.25	0.00	1.00
Ease of demonstration	Has no young kids	binary	732	0.65	0.48	0.00	1.00
	Single	binary	732	0.28	0.45	0.00	1.00
	Resides close to protests	binary	732	0.52	0.50	0.00	1.00
Main explanations	Out-bloc animosity	standardized	732	0.05	1.00	-1.60	1.47
	Dislike of Netanyahu	standardized	732	0.01	1.02	-1.51	1.34
	Ideologically Left-leaning	standardized	732	0.01	1.00	-1.57	2.72
	Definition of Democracy	standardized	732	-0.04	1.01	-2.28	1.18

Note: The table shows descriptive statistics of the main variables used in the analysis. For ease of interpretation, we report statistics for both standardized and binary measures of the key explanatory variables.

judicial overhaul. In column (1) the model includes only socio-demographic characteristics and measures of the cost of participation. As the results make clear, respondents' education level and degree of religiosity are consistent predictors of participation in protests against the judicial overhaul. More religious people—who tend to be stronger supporters of the current coalition parties—are systematically less likely to protest against the government's proposed overhaul. In contrast, more highely educated individuals are more likely to protest: among people with at least a college degree, participation is predicted to be 11 percentage points (pp) higher. Perhaps surprisingly, our measures of cost of participation (family circumstances and proximity to protests) are not associated with protest activity.

Next, we examine the empirical relationship between people's understandings of democracy and their likelihood of participation in the protests. As column (2) makes clear, the

Figure 1: Share of respondents protesting against the overhaul, by Conception of Democracy



Note: The top panel of the figure presents the share who protested against the overhaul, by conception of-democracy. (the share protesting shown in dark grey). The bottom panel presents the relative frequency of different conceptions of democracy across the full sample.

association is substantively strong and statistically significant. A one standard deviation shift in a respondent's conception of democracy away from majoritarianism is associated with a 10pp increase in likelihood of protest participation. Moreover, the fit of the model improves appreciably (from 0.11 to 0.16). Notably, the inclusion of people's conception of democracy weakens the coefficient of the education variable only slightly, highlighting the fact that the correlation between the two variables is modest.

Conceptions of democracy remain a strong predictor of protest participation also when we include in the model other factors that are expected to shape protest activity. dislike of Netanyahu (Model 3), out-bloc animosity (Model 4) and left-wing ideology (Model 5), are all associated with a 14-15 pp increase in the probability of participation in protest against the judicial overhaul. Yet as model 6 indicates, even after we account for these variables, a thicker conception of democracy remains strongly predictive of protest.

We note that despite the mass scale of the protests against the judicial reform, those who participated in the protests represent only a subset of the broader public opposing the reform, which according to polls, comprise between 60% to 70% of Israelis. In our sample,

Table 3: Predictors of protesting against the judicial overhaul

	Protest against						Oppose overhaul	Protest among opponents
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Woman	-0.03	-0.04	-0.03	-0.05	-0.04	-0.04	-0.03	-0.10†
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.05)
Academic	0.11**	0.08**	0.05†	0.06*	0.06*	0.05	0.01	0.10†
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.05)
Aged 35-54	-0.03	-0.04	-0.05	-0.03	-0.04	-0.04	-0.03	-0.09
	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.08)
Aged 55+	0.05	0.02	0.00	0.02	-0.01	-0.01	-0.02	-0.05
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.09)
Traditionalist	-0.19**	-0.17**	-0.08†	-0.07†	-0.09*	-0.05	-0.06†	-0.12
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.07)
Religious	-0.25**	-0.18**	-0.06	-0.03	-0.05	0.00	-0.17**	0.22
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.16)
Ultra-orthodox	-0.28**	-0.21**	-0.07	-0.02	-0.12*	-0.03	-0.17**	
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.05)	
Resides closer to protests	0.05	0.05†	0.04	0.04	0.04	0.04	-0.00	0.07
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.05)
Does not have little kids	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.02	0.01	0.03	0.07
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.06)
Not married	0.02	-0.00	0.01	-0.00	-0.02	-0.01	0.01	-0.05
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.05)
Thick conception		0.10**	0.05**	0.05**	0.06**	0.03*	0.05**	0.07†
		(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.03)
Dislike of Netanyahu			0.14**			0.07**	0.14**	0.07
			(0.02)			(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.05)
Out-bloc animosity				0.15**		0.05	0.19**	0.01
				(0.02)		(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.06)
Left leaning					0.14**	0.09**	0.03	0.11**
					(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)
Constant	0.22**	0.25**	0.24**	0.20**	0.24**	0.22**	0.58**	0.24*
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.11)
N	732	732	732	732	732	732	732	394
R^2	0.11	0.16	0.23	0.23	0.24	0.26	0.65	0.13

Note: The table shows results of a linear probability model. The sample excludes observations with missing values. The outcome variable is a binary indicator. The explanatory variables are standardized. The omitted baseline categories by the order shown in the table, are: "male"; "Aged 18-34"; "secular" (for religiosity); "No college degree"; "Has children younger than 10"; "Married" and: "resides outside the Tel-Aviv and Central districts". Standard errors in parentheses, † $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

only 40% of the respondents who opposed the overhaul said they also protested against it. Thus, while attitudinal opposition is a logical precondition for active mobilization, the two are both conceptually and empirically distinct. In the last two columns we assess whether

the empirical relationship we document between the explanatory variables and mobilization also holds with respect to attitudinal opposition to the overhaul, as well as whether these variables predict protest when focusing on the behavior of only those who oppose the reform.

In Model 7, where the dependent variable is attitudinal opposition to the overhaul (rather than participation in protest), we see again that a thick conception of democracy is a significant predictor of attitudinal opposition to backsliding. Interestingly, animosity towards the government and the backsliding leader are both strong and significant predictors of opposition to the reform—much more so than they are of protest participation. In Model 8 we limit the sample to only those who opposed the overhaul, and turn again to participation in the protests as our dependent variable. In this smaller sample, a thick conception of democracy is still predictive of participation in protests, albeit at $p<0.1$. Taken together, these results indicate that conception of democracy is a unique and consistent predictor of mobilization, and seems to go beyond the factors that sort individuals into attitudinal opposition to backsliding.

Next, we assess another aspect of the empirical relationship between democratic conceptions and mobilization against backsliding: whether thicker conceptions of democracy interact with other likely drivers of mobilization. Specifically, we examine whether people who dislike the leader or the opposing political camp are more likely to mobilize if they hold a thick conception of democracy.

Table 4 presents results of models that include interactions between conceptions of democracy and measures of the other key explanatory variables. Column 1 is similar to second column in the previous table and is included here to facilitate comparison to models 2-4. As column (2) shows, an interaction between dislike of Netanyahu and the thickness of respondents' democratic conception is positive, sizable and tightly estimated. A similar pattern with respect to the interaction is notable again when we use instead the measure of affective polarization (out-bloc animosity, column 3) or left-right ideology (column 4). That is, a thick conception of democracy is not only important as an independent predictor of participation in protest but also because it appears to reinforce the effects associated with the three other factors we highlighted that explain protest against the judicial overhaul.

These results are derived from regression models that rely on a non-obvious assumption

Table 4: Predictors of protesting against the judicial overhaul – interaction models

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Woman	-0.04	-0.04	-0.05†	-0.05†
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Academic	0.08**	0.05†	0.06*	0.06*
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Aged 35-54	-0.04	-0.06	-0.03	-0.04
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)
Aged 55+	0.02	-0.02	0.01	-0.02
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)
Traditionalist	-0.17**	-0.07†	-0.07†	-0.09*
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)
Religious	-0.18**	-0.07	-0.04	-0.06
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)
Ultra-orthodox	-0.21**	-0.08	-0.04	-0.12*
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)
Resides closer to protests	0.05†	0.04	0.05†	0.04
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Does not have little kids	0.01	0.00	0.01	0.02
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Not married	-0.00	-0.00	-0.01	-0.03
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Thick conception	0.10**	0.07**	0.07**	0.08**
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Dislike of Netanyahu		0.14**		
		(0.02)		
Thick conception x Dislike of Netanyahu		0.06**		
		(0.01)		
Out-bloc animosity			0.14**	
			(0.02)	
Thick conception x Out-bloc animosity			0.05**	
			(0.01)	
Left leaning				0.13**
				(0.02)
Thick conception x Left leaning				0.05**
				(0.01)
Constant	0.25**	0.23**	0.19**	0.23**
	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)
N	732	732	732	732
R^2	0.16	0.25	0.24	0.25

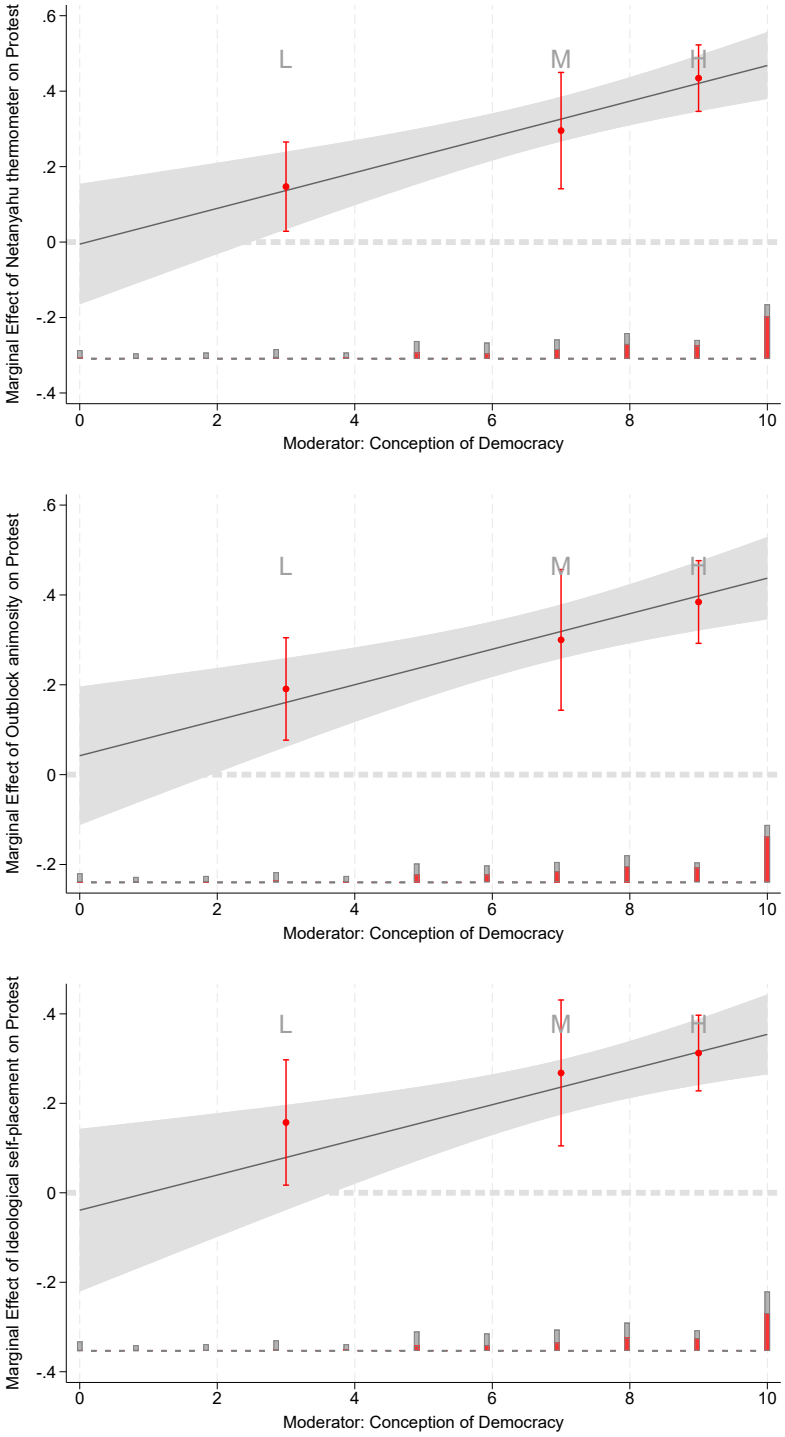
Note: The table shows results of a linear probability model. The sample excludes observations with missing values. The outcome variable is a binary indicator. The explanatory variables, including the interaction terms, are standardized. The omitted baseline categories by the order shown in the table, are: "male"; "Aged 18-34"; "secular" (for religiosity); "No college degree"; "Has children younger than 10"; "Married" and: "resides outside the Tel-Aviv and Central districts". Standard errors in parentheses, † $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

of a linear effect. To evaluate this assumption and provide a more intuitive interpretation of these interactions, we also examine the marginal effects of our ideological, affective and personalistic factors across different conceptions of democracy. To do so, we follow a diagnostic approach proposed by Hainmueller, Mummolo and Xu (2019) and present the results in Figure 2. Specifically, we discretize the measure of people's conception of democracy (i.e., the moderator variable) into three bins based on the terciles of the distribution (low, medium and high). We then interact the measure with each of the three explanations and present the marginal effects of each on the same graph with the estimated linear marginal-effect line. This allows us to assess in each case whether the assumption of a linear interaction effect (LIE) is justified. At the bottom of each panel, we present the distribution of values on the moderator variable. In all three panels of this figure, this distribution represents responses on the conceptions of democracy scale.[7]

As noted earlier and as the graph makes clear, the conceptions of democracy are spread throughout the scale but with a greater concentration in the higher values (i.e., a thick conception). Also, among those with a thicker conception, the share of respondents who dislike Netanyahu is higher.

[7]Each of the stacked bars is divided into the share of respondents for whom the binary explanatory variable is coded as one (in red) or zero (gray). For instance, in the case of the top panel, that refers to whether the respondent has a high degree of dislike for Netanyahu (red) or not (gray).

Figure 2: Marginal effect (ME) on protest participation by conception of democracy



Note: The figure presents the marginal effect of the explanatory variable on the probability of participating in the protests against the overhaul. In each panel the explanatory variable is different (from top to bottom): (a) Dislike of Netanyahu (ranging from low to high), (b) Out-bloc animosity (ranging from low to high), and (c) Ideological self-placement (ranging from right to left).

The top panel of Figure 2 shows that as one's conception of democracy is thicker (i.e, a rightward shift along the x-axis), dislike of Netanyahu corresponds with a higher propensity to demonstrate against the judicial overhaul. While dislike of the prime minister is associated with a 10pp probability of protest among those with a fully majoritarian understanding of democracy, it is associated with a four-fold increase (about 40%) in the probability of protest among those with a thick understanding of democracy. Notably, the three estimates from the binning estimator (labeled L, M, and H) are all nicely located on the estimated linear marginal effect line from the standard multiplicative interaction model, indicating that the LIE assumption holds.

Moving to the middle panel in Figure 2, we again see that out-bloc animosity, that is, affective polarization, more strongly predicts protest among those with less of a majoritarian conception of democracy. Here, however, the relationship is not fully linear, as there is no statistically significant difference between those in the low and medium terciles. Nonetheless, among those holding the thickest understanding of democracy, affective polarization is associated with a strong and statistically significant effect on protest. A similar pattern emerges when we consider ideological self-placement in the bottom panel: shifting to a more leftist position predicts protest participation at a higher rate among those with a thicker conception of democracy.

To summarize, the evidence indicates that people's understanding of democracy conditions their willingness to protest against backsliding. We have also demonstrated that dislike of the leader advancing backsliding and of his coalition parties, as well as ideological opposition, are more likely to translate into protest among those who hold a strictly thick view of democracy.

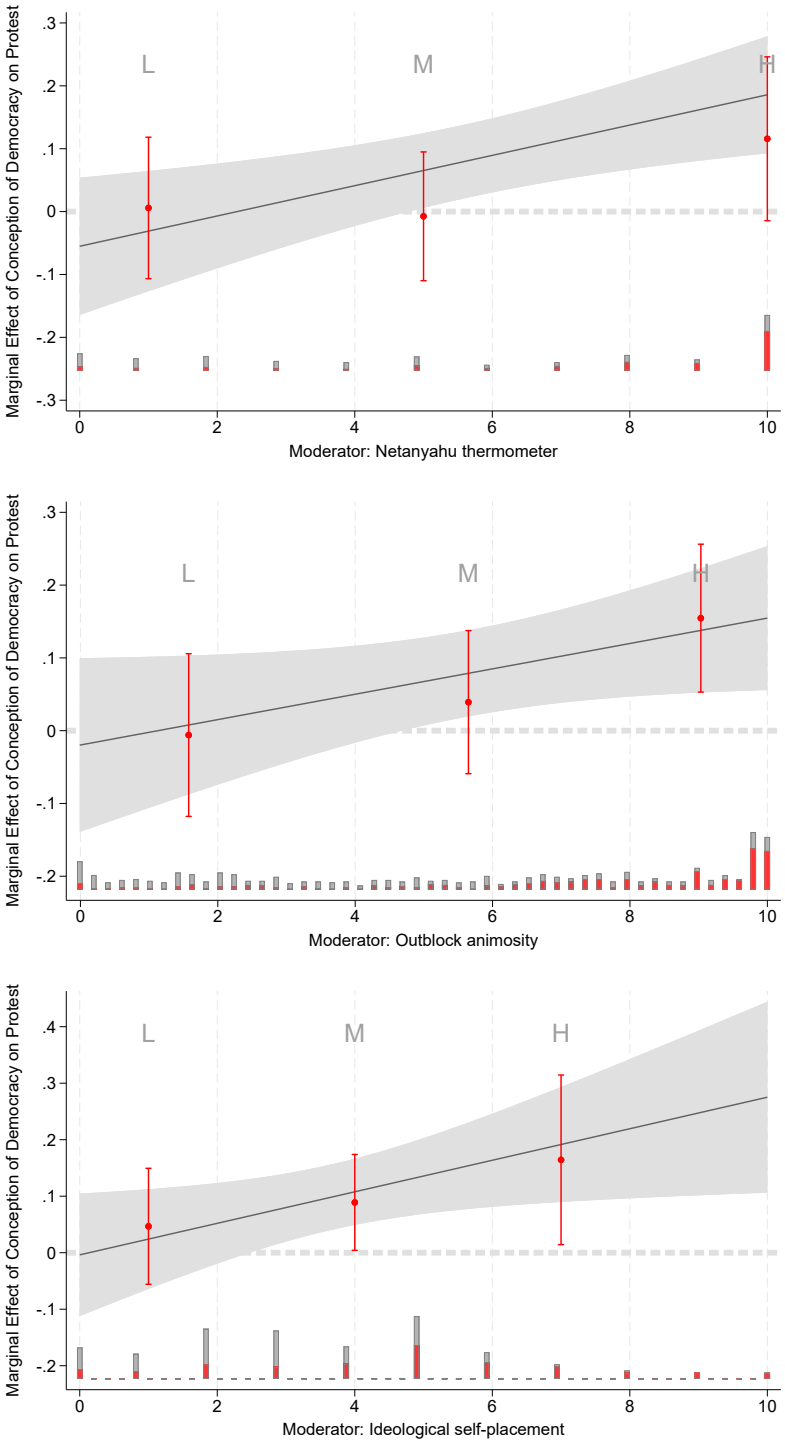
Finally, we examine how shifting from a narrow to a thick conception of democracy changes the predicted likelihood of protesting across different levels of the personalistic, affective and ideological factors we emphasized above. Figure 3 provides insight on this question. Again, we discretize our measures of affect toward Netanyahu and out-bloc animosity into three bins based on the terciles (low, medium and high). We also divide the ideological self-placement reverse-coded scale to three categories: right (0-3), center (4-6), and left (7-10).

In the top panel we see that moving from a more majoritarian to a less majoritarian understanding of democracy has a positive marginal effect on protest only among those who strongly dislike Netanyahu, but not among those with positive to lukewarm feelings toward him. While the assumption of a linear interaction effect does not hold, we nonetheless see that a thick understanding of democracy is associated with an increase in the probability of mobilization by more than 10 percentage points among those who hold a very negative view of the leader advancing the backsliding drive.

The empirical relationship appears to be more linear in the middle panel, showing the marginal effect of conception of democracy across different levels of out-bloc animosity. Here we find that a less majoritarian understanding of democracy corresponds with more than a 15pp increase in the propensity to protest among those who strongly dislike the coalition parties. In contrast, among those with low levels of affective polarization, the marginal effect cannot be distinguished from zero.

Lastly, the bottom panel shows the marginal effect of understandings of democracy when conditioning on ideological self-placement. The figure indicates that among voters on the right, a thicker conception of democracy is not associated with a higher likelihood of protest mobilization against the overhaul. However, the effect is significant and sizable among voters in both the center (8pp) and the left (18pp).

Figure 3: Marginal effects on participation in protests against the judicial overhaul, across different conceptions of democracy



Note: The figure presents the marginal effect of a thick conception of democracy on the probability of participating in the protests against the overhaul. In each panel the moderator is different (from top to bottom): (a) Dislike of Netanyahu (ranging from low to high), (b) Out-bloc animosity (ranging from low to high), and (c) Ideological self-placement (right, center and left)).

5.1 How Malleable are Conceptions of Democracy?

The analysis so far shows that people's conception of democracy is an important factor in explaining their likelihood of contesting democratic backsliding. This raises two main questions: (a) who are the people that hold a thick conception of democracy; and (b) are people's conceptions entrenched, or do they change over time? The second question is especially relevant within the time frame covered in this study, when public debates about the nature of democracy took center stage.

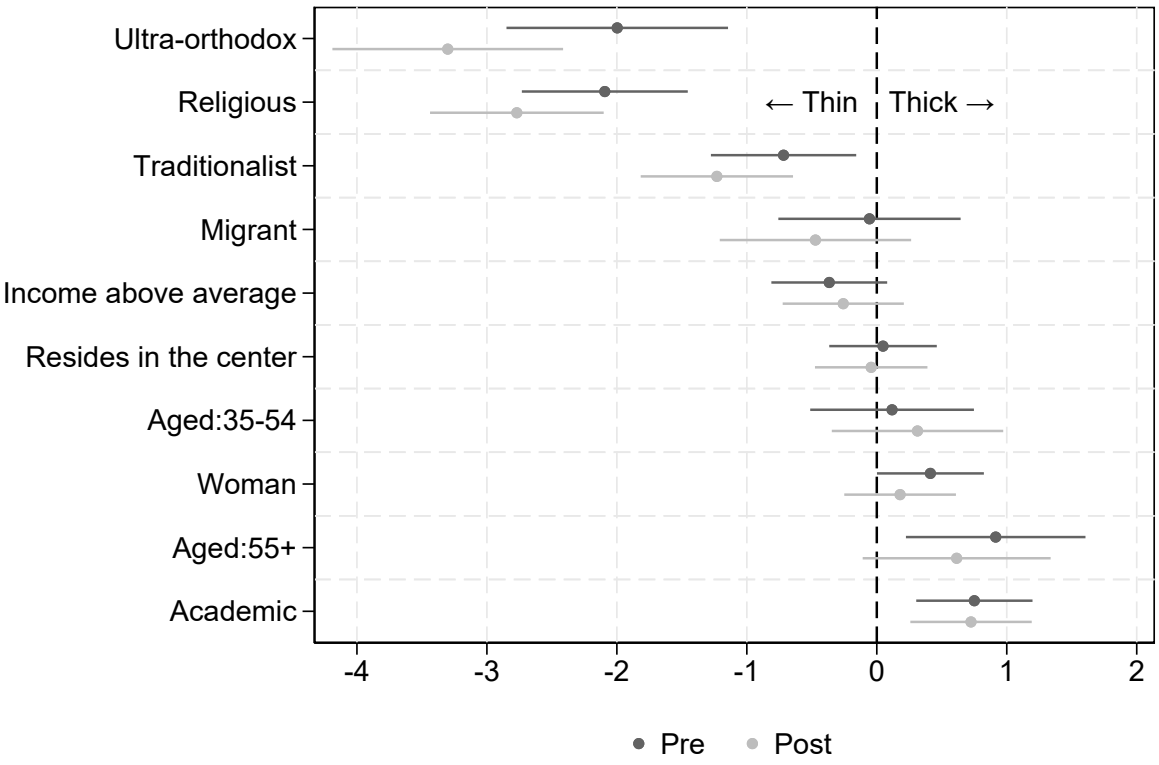
To get at these questions, we conduct two analyses in which we consider conceptions of democracy as the dependent variable. First, we regress the outcome of democratic conception (11-point scale ranging from thin [0] to thick [10]) on a range of demographic characteristics. As Figure 4 shows, two demographic factors stand out: religion and education. Religiosity is strongly and negatively associated with a thick conception. In contrast, an academic degree, as well as older age, are positively and significantly associated with a thick conception. This indicates that conceptions of democracy are associated with demographic features that are slow-moving or time-invariant.

When we estimate the same model but with people's conception in the April 2024 wave, i.e., *after* several months of national debate over the judicial overhaul and its implications on Israeli democracy, the same predictors still apply. The only notable change is that religiosity has become an even stronger predictor of a thin conception of democracy. Does the overall stability of the predictors imply that people's conceptions remained fixed, despite the tumultuous period of protests against the judicial overhaul and the lively public debate surrounding it?

Figure 5 presents the distribution of *changes* in conceptions of democracy between the two survey waves, subsetting the sample for supporters of coalition and opposition parties (Figure A1 in the online appendix documents these changes across the various parties). The figure indicates that there was overall a high degree of stability, particularly among voters for the opposition. But to the extent that attitudes did shift, we observe a *polarization* in conceptions: voters for opposition parties adopted an even thicker understanding of democracy while supporters of the coalition adopted an even more majoritarian (thin) conception.

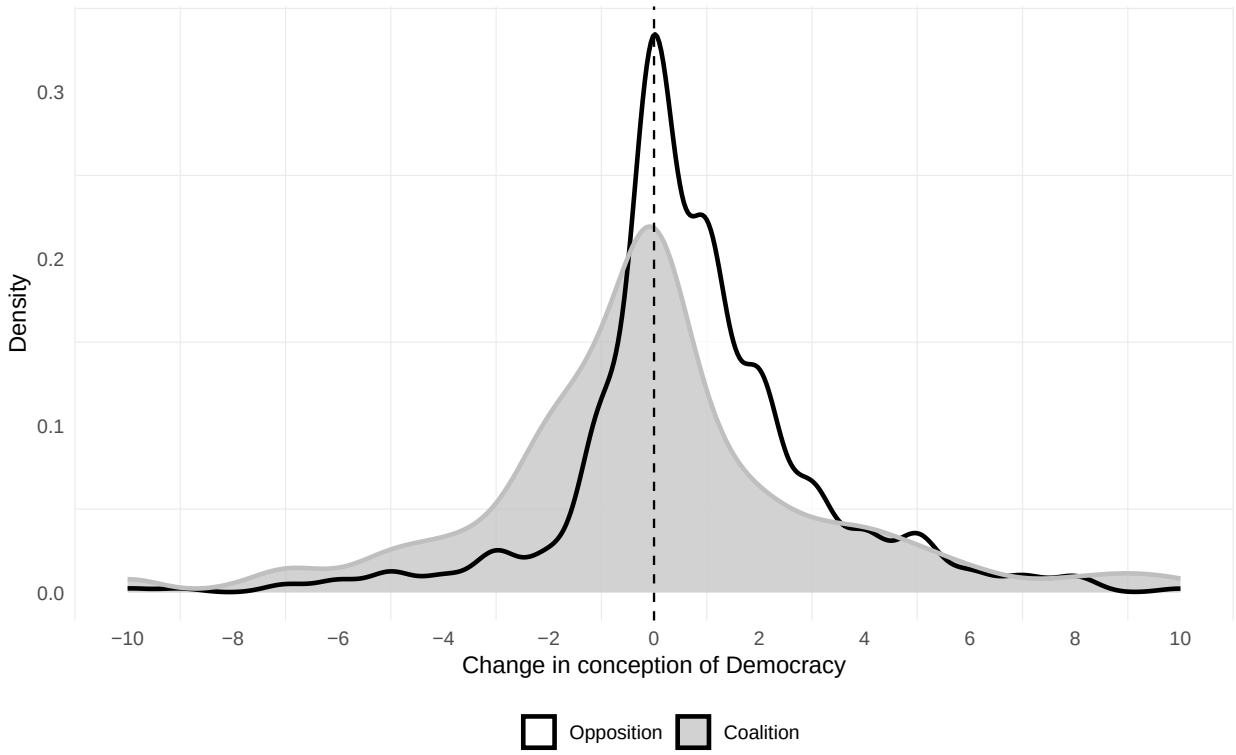
This probably reflects the fact that politicians from both sides were vocally making the case for their preferred understanding of democracy: those on the right were emphasizing that the government had a mandate to overhaul the democratic system due its majority in parliament, while the opposition attacked the government for subverting democracy by promoting an overhaul that would weaken checks on executive power and trample basic civil liberties. As these patterns clearly indicate, further inquiry into the malleability of people's conceptions of democracy seems a worthy direction for future research.

Figure 4: Predictors of Conception of Democracy, by panel wave



Note: The figure shows coefficients from two regressions: the first includes a dependent variable which is the original 11-point variable capturing the conception of democracy as measured in January 2023, and the second includes a dependent variable which is the same variable measured in April 2023, after the introduction of the overhaul . For the variables denoting respondent's level of religiosity, the baseline category is "Secular"; for age-groups the omitted category is "up to 34".

Figure 5: Distribution of *change in CoD* between waves, by initial political block



Note: The figure shows the density of the change in the Conception of Democracy measure between waves. The density is presented separately for supporters of coalition and opposition parties, based on their vote int the last elections. The change is calculated by subtracting the January 2023 measurement from the April 2023 measurement for each participant. Values larger than zero imply that the participant moved toward a thicker conception of Democracy (relative to her pre-overhaul position). Conversely, negative values mean that the participant moved toward a more majoritarian view of Democracy.

6 Discussion

As concerns over the future of democracy intensify (Diamond, 2024; Levitsky and Way, 2023; Riedl, McCoy, Roberts and Somer, 2024; Riedl, Friesen, McCoy and Roberts, 2024), scholars have focused on investigating support for democratic backsliding. Notably, far less is known about who resists and protests against such processes. Our study examined this question in the Israeli context, where a wholesale effort to weaken the courts and concentrate power in the hands of the executive branch was met with one of the most sizable and persistent anti-backsliding protests in recent history. What explains people's decision to participate in the demonstrations against the judicial overhaul, and what does the answer tell us about the underpinnings of mass resistance to democratic backsliding?

To address these questions, we analyzed novel panel data that we began collecting before the overhaul was publicized, allowing us to allay concerns about reverse causality. Our analyses examined the role of mass conceptions of democracy in facilitating protest against backsliding and paid close attention also to the role of ideological, affective, and personalistic features of the political system. While our empirical results are derived from a single-country case study, the factors we examined are very likely relevant also in other contexts where democracy is challenged by an elected government.

To survive against efforts to subvert it, democracy needs small-d democrats: this is one of the key findings that emerged from our empirical analyses. A view of democracy that is not strictly majoritarian is associated with a greater likelihood not only opposing backsliding but also of protesting against it. This is the case when examined independently, but also when interacted with other prominent factors: dislike of the leader advancing the backsliding charge and the parties in his coalition, as well as with ideological opposition to the government. These considerations, we show, are systematically more likely to predict protest participation among those who hold a non-majoritarian understanding of democracy. Thus, whatever way one looks at it, a thicker view of democracy appears to be an important factor in facilitating protest against backsliding.

The extent to which civic education can cultivate a deeper public understanding of democracy may influence a democracy's capacity to resist top-down attempts to undermine it. However, as our findings suggest, a thick conception of democracy is unlikely to be sufficient on its own. It would be misguided to assume that public opinion alone can serve as a panacea against democratic subversion. Other factors–such as the strength of political institutions and the behavior of elites–play a critical role in sustaining democratic resilience (Nyhan and Titiunik, 2024). Accordingly, our focus on the determinants of citizens' resistance to democratic backsliding should be understood within this broader context.

Scholars have closely examined whether, how and to what degree affective polarization can facilitate democratic backsliding (Broockman, Kalla and Westwood, 2023; Druckman et al., 2024; McCoy and Somer, 2019). Our analysis turns this perspective on its head and suggests that dislike of political opponents can also help galvanize protest against parties advancing democratic backsliding. The same holds for personalized politics: While those

who are strongly attached to strongmen leaders may support their efforts to destabilize democracy (Frantz, Kendall-Taylor and Wright, 2024), personalization and strong dislike of such leaders likely help explain opposition to their backsliding efforts. And when coupled with a thick understanding of democracy, these affective and personalistic factors reinforce one another, as our analyses indicate.

Beyond their practical implications, these findings also raise a normative question: Is dislike toward parties and leaders advancing democratic backsliding necessarily bad, considering their role in facilitating protest in defense of democracy? Addressing this question is beyond the scope of this paper, but our results do suggest that intense negative emotions may serve not only to erode democracy but also to protect it.

Our results also highlight the importance of constructing a broad pro-democracy coalition that extends beyond the fiercest ideological opposition to the government. The findings show that, as expected, people on the left were the most likely to participate in the protest against the judicial overhaul advanced by the right. But at the same time, leftists constitute only a distinct minority of the Israeli electorate. Thus, our finding that a thicker understanding of democracy was associated with greater participation in protest also among centrist voters is pertinent. In fact, much of the power of the protest movement in Israel stemmed exactly from its success in bringing together a broad coalition of leftist and centrist voters (and even some on the center-right). Notably, this coalition became harder to keep together after the October 7th attack, which upended the country's political landscape.

Research on opposition to democratic backsliding is still in its early stages, despite important advances in the field (Cleary and Öztürk, 2022; Gamboa, 2022; Tomini, Gibril and Bochev, 2023; van Lit, van Ham and Meijers, 2024). In line with recent evidence (Jacob, 2024; Kaftan and Gessler, 2024; Wunsch, Jacob and Derksen, 2025), our results highlight the role of popular conceptions of democracy. Future research should investigate the origins of these conceptions, the contexts in which they take shape, and their stability over time. For such conceptions to serve as an effective bulwark against backsliding, thick understandings of democracy must endure even amid periods of crisis. Determining whether–and under what conditions–these democratic commitments can remain steadfast is not only an empirical challenge, but also a pressing task for those seeking to understand how democracies survive.

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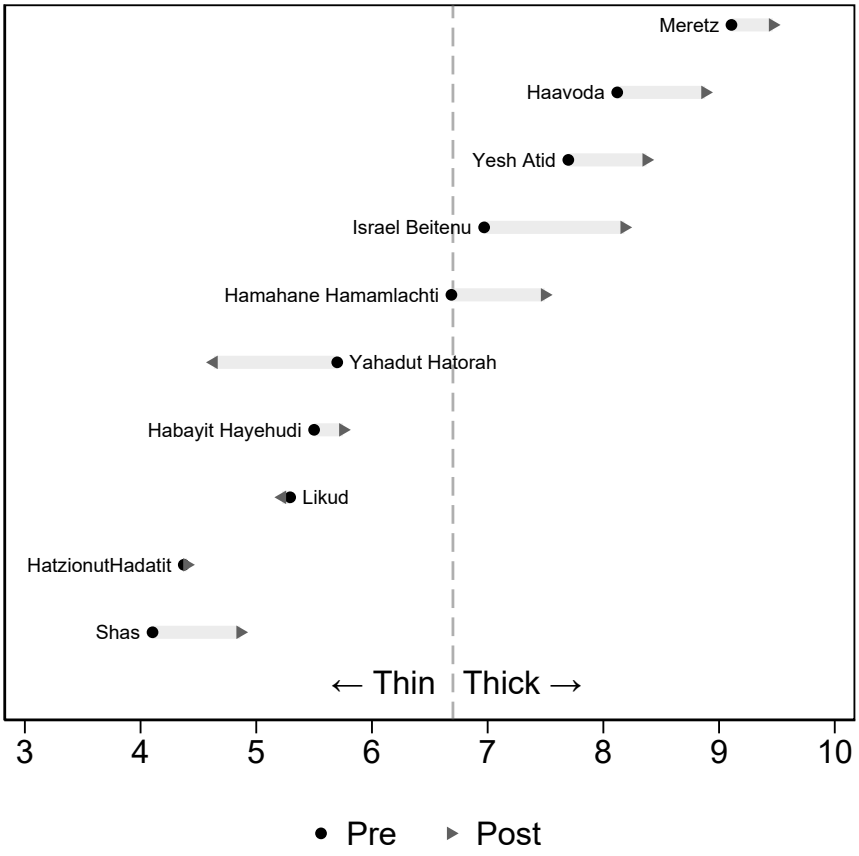
Online Appendix

Resistance to Backsliding: The Role of Democratic Conceptions

Figure A1: Changes in the Conception of Democracy score across waves, by party



Note: The figure shows the mean score of the Conception of Democracy measure across two consecutive panel waves, collected in before and after the announcement of the judicial overhaul (denoted in circles and triangles, respectively). The parties listed are those that participants had voted for in the previous elections (Arab Parties that include small number of observations and the "don't know / other" categories are not shown). The vertical line, at 6.7, marks the sample mean score across both waves.